FINDING · BASELINE

Conversion was 78.3 percent, 72 of 92, with saves and misses kept apart

78.3%
72 of 92 converted

15.2%
14 saved

6.5%
6 off target



Goal 72 Saved 14 Missed 6

FINDING · PLACEMENT

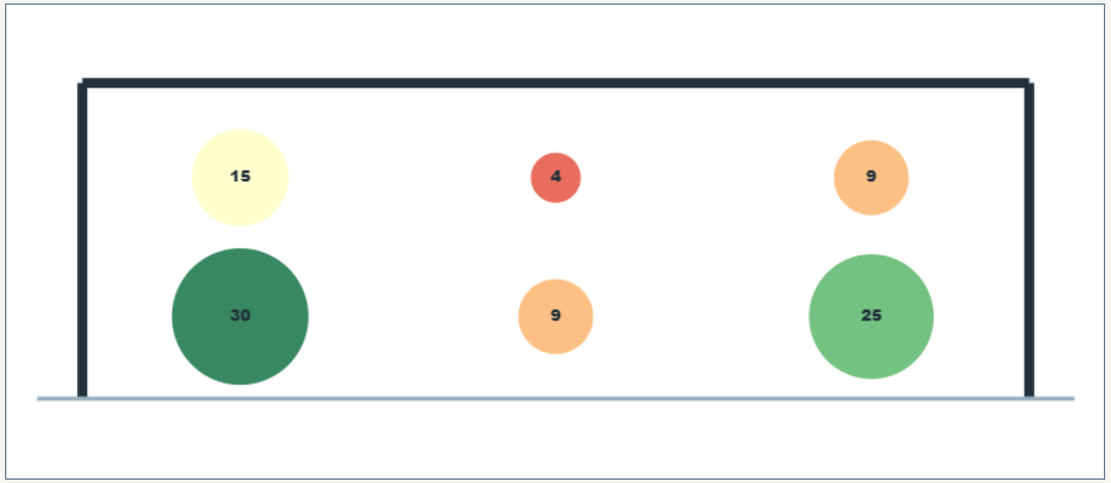
Height is a trade, not an edge

59.8%
55 of 92 low and wide

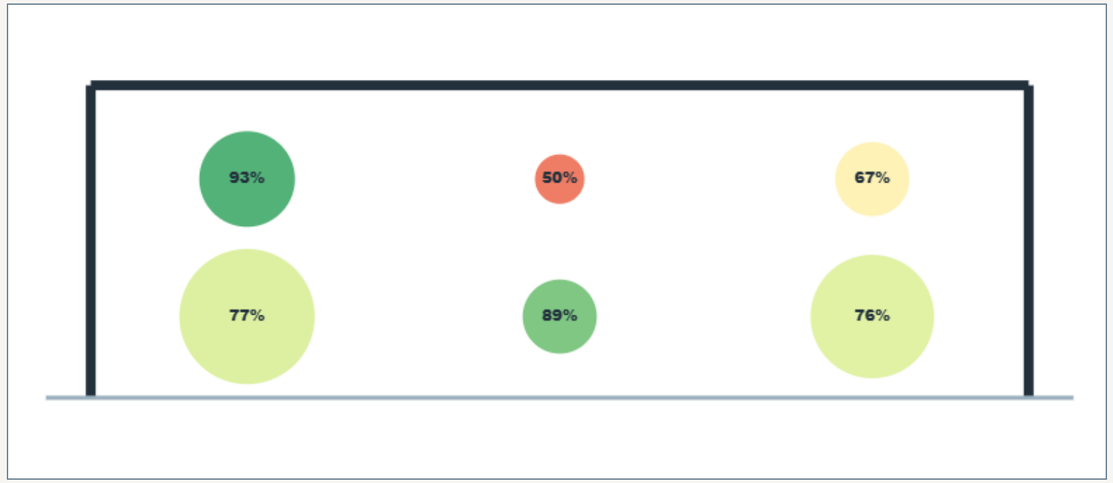
78.6%
high converted, 22 of 28

78.1%
low converted, 50 of 64

Penalties by zone



Conversion by zone



Bubble size is n. Colour tracks the same scale in each panel. High kicks are saved less and missed more; the two cancel.

FINDING · CONTEXT

In-match penalties converted 91.8%; shootouts converted 62.8%

91.8%
45 of 49 in open play

62.8%
27 of 43 in shootouts

p ≈ 0.0009
conversion gap, goal vs not

The gap is almost entirely saves: 4.1% (2 of 49) in play against 27.9% (12 of 43) in shootouts. That save-rate test has a Fisher exact of p ≈ 0.0025.
Takers went high more often in shootouts (41.9% vs 20.4%), but height does not move conversion as established earlier, so that cannot explain 29 points of difference

Keepers dived just as often in both contexts. What the coding cannot see is kick quality under pressure.

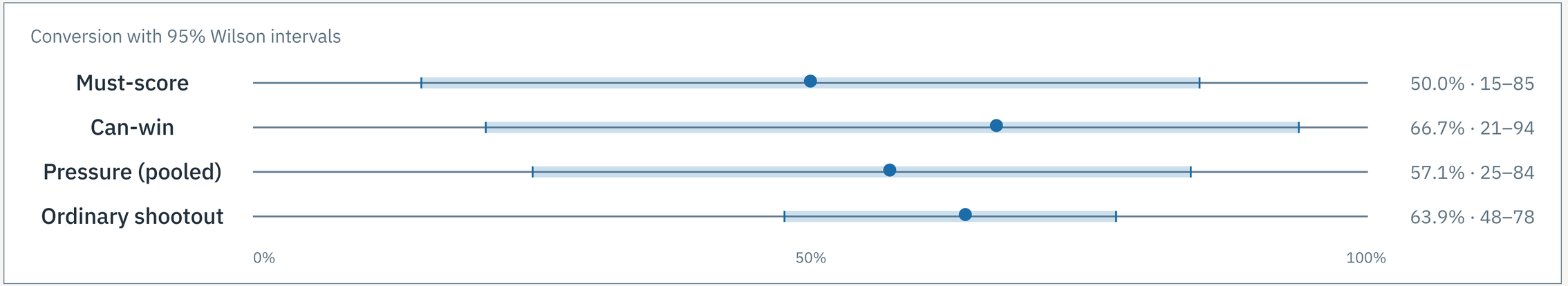
Must-score and can-win kicks do not survive seven events

4/7
pressure converted, 57.1%

23/36
ordinary shootout, 63.9%

p = 1.0
no evidence of a stake gap

Must-score kicks went in 2 of 4 times. Can-win kicks went in 2 of 3. Pool them as pressure and the sample still cannot tell them from ordinary shootout kicks.



The tiny groups span most of the unit interval. One season of Hong Kong shootouts cannot answer stakes.

FINDING · CENTRE

Keepers should stay central more often; the middle is almost never guarded

14.1%
13 of 92 aimed down the middle

5.4%
5 of 92, keeper stayed central

11/13
middle kicks, keeper already gone

Takers use the middle more than twice as often as keepers stay there. Of those 13 middle kicks, the keeper was already gone on 11: 10 goals, 1 miss, no saves. Only two met a keeper who stayed, and both were saved.

The save-rate claim is still thin: 40% on five stays (Wilson 11.8–76.9%) overlaps the 13.8% dive save rate ($p \approx 0.16$). Raise the stay-central share first. Prove the rate later.

FINDING · FOOT

Left-footed takers converted 52.4 percent against 85.9 for the right foot

52.4%
11 of 21 left-footed

85.9%
61 of 71 right-footed

p ≈ 0.002
unlikely if both feet converted equally

18 players share the 21 left foot kicks, and nobody took more than three. The gap is also not a shootout mix: left-foot conversion sits lower in both in-match penalties and shootouts, though the shootout half is still thin.

In-match: 66.7% vs 97.5%. Shootouts: 41.7% vs 71.0%. The interval on 52.4% still runs roughly 32–72%. This dataset cannot explain why.

FINDING · FOOT, CONTINUED

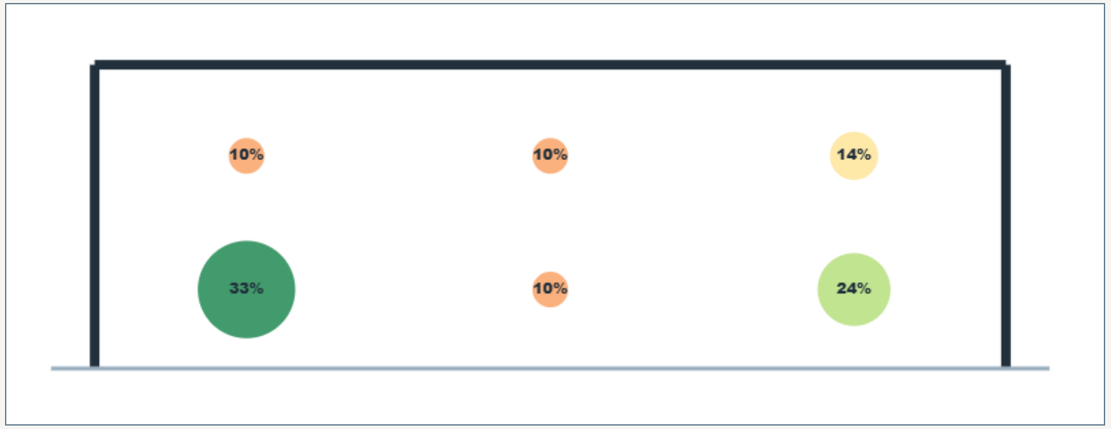
The two feet aimed at the same places, which makes the gap stranger

p ≈ 0.79
same left vs right third mix

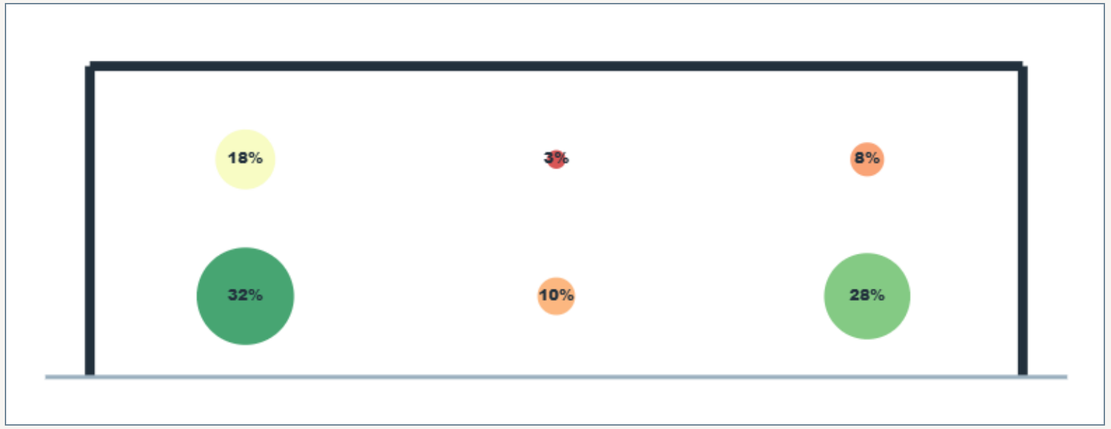
p ≈ 0.48
same centre vs sides mix

p ≈ 0.79
same high vs low mix

Left foot · 21 kicks



Right foot · 71 kicks



Both feet put about a third into low-left. Shot selection does not explain the conversion gap. Keepers matched 66.7% of left-foot kicks vs 47.9% of right-foot, p ≈ 0.14. Next check: are left-footers mostly left backs and defenders, or is the gap still there inside the same playing position?

CANNOT ANSWER

What 92 kicks cannot rank

Players. The busiest keeper faced 14 kicks. 39 of 56 shooters took exactly one. Even a perfect 8-from-8 still has a Wilson interval that contains the 78.3% season baseline, so one hot streak does not clear the average. Left-footed takers are the same problem in reverse: 21 kicks across 18 players is enough to see a group gap, not enough to name who is driving it.

Hesitation run-ups. 13 of 18 (72.2%) vs 58 of 73 normal (79.5%), $p \approx 0.53$. A genuine null: large advantage ruled out, small edge still possible.

Open from the keeper pages. Whether diving correctly cause taker to miss more, and whether to stand still. One needs several seasons of misses; the other needs about four more central kicks at the same rate.

SAMPLE

Where the 92 kicks came from



FA Cup

40

34 shootout · 6 in-match



HKPL

33

All in-match



Senior Shield

14

9 shootout · 5 in-match



League Cup

5

All in-match

HOW THE DATA ARE COLLECTED

Every kick was hand-coded from match video

The fixture and award list comes from official HKFA Data. 44 matches across these four competitions, season window 30 Aug 2025 to 30 May 2026.